

UX & Conversion Audit

therapistlysander.com

Emotional UX, Trauma-Informed Design & Premium Conversion Analysis for
a Psychotherapy Practice

Prepared: May 2025

Target audiences: Trauma therapy clients | Private-pay clients | Expats/International clients

Prepared by

Rakesh Maity

Senior Software Engineer

Custom Laravel Development | Scalable Web Systems

Executive Summary

This audit evaluates therapistlysander.com across emotional UX, conversion architecture, premium positioning, and trauma-informed design principles. The site has a solid therapeutic philosophy and genuine personal narrative, but is undermined by structural conversion failures, insufficient trust signals, and visual execution that reads as DIY rather than premium.

EMOTIONAL SAFETY 5.5/10	CONVERSION 4/10	PREMIUM FEEL 5/10
MOBILE UX 6/10	TYPOGRAPHY 5.5/10	TRUST SIGNALS 4.5/10

1. Main Website Problems

PROBLEM	IMPACT
No above-the-fold CTA	Visitors must scroll entire page to find booking options
Gmail address as contact	Immediately kills premium positioning
Single testimonial only	Woefully insufficient for private-pay conversion
AI-generated imagery (ChatGPT graphic)	Signals low brand investment
Wix platform limitations	Default blue links, limited design control, footer attribution
Text-wall structure	No visual chunking, icons, or breathing room
No booking system	WhatsApp/email is high-friction for anxious clients
Dutch language bleed	Skip link in Dutch breaks English-only intent

2. Emotional & Psychological UX Issues

Trauma-Informed Design Failures

- CRITICAL

Dense paragraph blocks without visual breaks force trauma clients into sustained reading — the exact thing they struggle with when dysregulated. Trauma clients scan; they don't read walls of text.
- CRITICAL

No "what happens next" clarity. When someone with anxiety decides to reach out, ambiguity about the process creates anticipatory dread.
- HIGH

Justified text alignment creates uneven word spacing that subtly disrupts reading flow — the micro-level equivalent of unpredictability.
- HIGH

Full-body portrait in hero (1919px tall) feels more "model" than "safe person." A warmer, cropped shoulders-up image with natural lighting would create more intimacy.
- HIGH

No explicit safety signals: no mention of confidentiality, no "you're in control of the pace," no acknowledgment that reaching out is hard.
- MEDIUM

Emotional language before relational trust. The site jumps into deep therapeutic language before establishing who this person is as a human.

Core Principle Violated

The first emotional beat should be: **"You're safe here. Here's what to expect."** Not: "Here's my clinical methodology." Front-load warmth and containment.

3. Mobile Optimization Improvements

CRITICAL No sticky CTA — contact section is 8-10 screen-scrolls deep on mobile. A floating "Book a Free Consultation" button is essential.

HIGH Hero image (610x1919px) will dominate mobile viewport, pushing all content far below the fold.

HIGH Touch targets for WhatsApp and email need minimum 48px with adequate spacing between them.

MEDIUM Content prioritization: mobile should lead with 2-line value prop then immediate CTA. Methodology belongs below or on subpage.

MEDIUM Navigation needs a pinned "Book Now" CTA in the mobile header bar.

Recommended Mobile Hierarchy

- Warm portrait (cropped, max 40vh)
- 1-sentence value proposition
- Primary CTA button
- "Does this sound like you?" validation section
- Brief credentials
- Testimonial snippet
- Floating sticky CTA throughout scroll

4. Typography & Spacing Recommendations

Current State

Futura Light at 60px for H1, 24px subheadings. Body defaults to system sans-serif. Justified alignment throughout.

Problems Identified

- Futura Light at display size feels cold and architectural — not warm/therapeutic
- Justified body text creates rivers of whitespace
- No typographic rhythm (inconsistent section spacing)
- Line height and letter spacing not optimized for readability
- Content width unrestricted — lines too long for comfortable reading

Recommended Changes

ELEMENT	CURRENT	RECOMMENDED
Heading font	Futura Light	Warmer serif (Cormorant Garamond, Freight Display) or rounded sans (Circular, Sofia Pro)
Body font	System sans-serif	Inter, DM Sans, or Outfit
H1 size	60px	42-48px, medium weight
Body alignment	Justified	Left-aligned
Line height	Default (~1.4)	1.7-1.8 for body text
Paragraph spacing	Minimal	24-32px between paragraphs
Section spacing	Inconsistent	80-120px between major sections
Max content width	Full-width	640-720px text column

Typography Psychology

For trauma therapy audiences, typography should feel: unhurried, spacious, gentle, and clear. Avoid sharp geometric fonts (they feel clinical). Prefer fonts with humanist proportions — rounded terminals, open apertures, comfortable x-heights. The goal is a reading experience that mirrors the therapeutic relationship: calm, spacious, and unhurried.

5. Conversion & Lead-Generation Improvements

Current Conversion Architecture (Score: 3/10)

Visitor → Scroll entire page → Find WhatsApp/Email at bottom → Compose message → Wait for reply → ??

Recommended Conversion Architecture

Visitor → Click "Book Free Consultation" (visible immediately) → Choose time slot (Cal.com/Calendly) → Brief intake form → Confirmation email → 15-min call → First session

Key Conversion Recommendations

- **Offer a free 15-minute consultation call** — industry standard for private-pay therapy. Lowers commitment threshold dramatically.
- **Add a sticky CTA** reading "Book a Free 15-Minute Call" — visible at every scroll position.
- **Replace WhatsApp as primary CTA** with a scheduling tool (Cal.com is free, clean, professional). Keep WhatsApp as secondary channel.
- **Add "What Happens When You Reach Out" section** with clear numbered steps.
- **Add mid-page micro-commitments:** "Does this sound like you?" checklist, anchor links to booking.
- **Address objections explicitly:** Cost, "Am I bad enough?", time commitment, "Will it work?"
- **Add scarcity signal:** "Currently accepting X new clients per month" or "Limited availability."

Missing Conversion Elements

ELEMENT	IMPACT ON CONVERSION
Free consultation offer	Can increase bookings 40-60%
Pricing transparency (range)	Reduces anxiety, qualifies leads
Scheduling tool	Removes "compose a message" friction
FAQ section	Handles objections, reduces bounce
Multiple testimonials	Social proof drives conversion 20-35%
Process explanation	Reduces unknown-fear for anxious clients

6. Homepage Refinement Ideas

Current Structure (Problematic)

Hero → Dense about text → Quote → Methods list → Trauma explanation → Conditions → 1 Testimonial → Contact

Recommended Structure

#	SECTION	PURPOSE
1	Hero: Warm portrait + 1-sentence value prop + CTA	Immediate clarity and action path
2	Validation: "If you're feeling..." (3-4 pain points)	Emotional recognition / "you get me"
3	About Lysander: 3-4 sentences + link to full bio	Human connection and trust
4	How I Work: Visual 3-step process	Remove ambiguity and fear of unknown
5	Specializations: Icon grid (max 6)	Credibility and relevance confirmation
6	Testimonials: 3 rotating quotes	Social proof and outcome visualization
7	"What to Expect" step-by-step	Process clarity for anxious visitors
8	FAQ: 4-5 common questions	Objection handling
9	Final CTA: Full-width calm section	Conversion capture
10	Footer: Credentials, privacy, contact	Professional completion

Key Principles for Homepage

- Lead with empathy, not credentials
- Maximum 2-3 sentences per text block
- Every section should have a visual element (icon, image, or whitespace)
- CTA should appear minimum 3 times on the page
- Progressive disclosure: overview on homepage, depth on subpages

7. Booking Flow Improvements

Current Flow (High Friction)

- No structured booking path
- WhatsApp requires client to initiate and compose a message
- Email requires subject line creation and message drafting
- No response time expectation set
- No timezone clarity for international clients
- No intake information gathered upfront

Recommended Booking System

- **Tool:** Cal.com (free tier), Calendly, or Acuity Scheduling
- **Offer:** "Book a Free 15-Minute Discovery Call"
- **Intake form fields:** Name, Email, Timezone, "What brings you to therapy?" (2-3 sentences max), Preferred session type (online/in-person)
- **Confirmation:** Automated email with what to expect on the call
- **Follow-up:** Automated reminder 24h before

Timezone Considerations (for Expat Clients)

- Display available hours in multiple timezones
- Clearly state "Sessions available across timezones" on homepage
- Scheduling tool should auto-detect visitor timezone
- State clearly: "Online sessions via secure video platform"

WhatsApp Optimization

Keep WhatsApp as a secondary/preferred channel (especially for Asia-Pacific market) but pre-populate the message:

```
wa.me/66935309052?text=Hi%20Lysander%2C%20I'm%20interested%20in%20booking%20a%20consultation.%20My%20name%20is%20
```

This removes the "what do I say?" anxiety that prevents trauma clients from reaching out.

8. Visual Polish Recommendations

Area	Current Issue	Recommended Fix
Color palette	Default blue links break sage-green palette	Unify all interactive elements to palette (sage, muted teal)
Imagery	AI-generated ChatGPT image visible	Replace with professional photography or curated high-quality stock
Office/space photos	Tiny 123px thumbnails	Full-width, aspirational images of the therapy space
White space	Insufficient between sections	80-120px vertical rhythm between major sections
Button design	Flat, low-contrast WhatsApp button	Higher contrast, larger padding (16px 32px), subtle hover state
Wix attribution	"Built with Wix" in footer	Upgrade plan or migrate to remove
Favicon/branding	Default or missing	Custom subtle monogram or mark
Loading experience	Standard Wix loader	Custom smooth fade-in animation
Scroll behavior	Abrupt section transitions	Subtle fade-in on scroll (IntersectionObserver)

Photography Direction

- **Portrait:** Warm, natural light. Shoulders-up crop. Genuine expression (not posed smile). Neutral/earth-tone clothing.
- **Environment:** Clean therapy space, warm textures, plants, natural materials. Shot with depth of field.
- **Details:** Hands holding a cup, journal and pen, soft textile textures, natural light through window.
- **Avoid:** Staged/stock feeling, harsh lighting, cluttered backgrounds, clinical settings.

9. Premium UI/UX Upgrade Strategy

Platform Migration: Wix to Custom Build

To move from "competent Wix site" to "premium private-pay therapist brand," the recommended path is migrating from Wix to a **custom-built website** using a modern framework (Laravel + Blade/Livewire or a static-first approach).

Why a Custom Build?

- **Full design control** — pixel-perfect implementation of therapeutic aesthetics with no platform constraints
- **Performance** — faster load times, optimized assets, no bloated platform JS
- **SEO ownership** — complete control over meta, schema markup, sitemaps, and server-side rendering
- **No forced branding** — no "Built with Wix" footer, no platform attribution
- **Scalability** — blog, client portal, booking integration, multilingual support — all without platform limitations
- **Security & compliance** — proper data handling for therapy client inquiries (GDPR-ready)

Why Wix must go: Wix structurally limits premium perception through forced footer attribution, limited typography control, template-feeling layouts, slower load times, and inability to implement custom booking flows or advanced interactions.

Brand System Requirements

- Custom domain email (lysander@therapistlysander.com)
- Consistent color palette applied to every element (no default blues)
- Professional photography session (portrait + therapy space + details)
- Subtle animation language (fade-ins, smooth transitions)
- Custom 404 page
- Privacy policy and terms page
- Proper SSL and professional hosting

Premium Signals to Add

- "Limited availability — currently accepting [X] new clients per month"
- Professional credentials with verification links
- Association memberships / certification logos
- Published articles or media features (if any)
- A "My Approach" page that reads as a mini-manifesto, not a CV
- Client outcome metrics or satisfaction rates

Design Language for Premium Therapy

ELEMENT	PREMIUM SIGNAL
Whitespace	Generous — signals confidence and intentionality
Typography	Considered pairings — serif + sans or two complementary sans
Color	Restrained palette (3-4 colors max) with one intentional accent
Photography	Original, warm, high-quality — no stock feeling
Micro-interactions	Subtle hover states, smooth transitions, thoughtful loading
Content density	Less text, more space — every word earns its place
Navigation	Minimal, clear, with persistent CTA

10. Step-by-Step Refinement Roadmap

Phase 1: Quick Wins (Highest Impact)

- Add a sticky/floating CTA button: "Book a Free Consultation"
- Set up Cal.com (free) or Calendly for scheduling
- Replace Gmail with custom domain email
- Remove or replace the AI-generated image
- Add 2-3 more testimonials (even anonymized with initials)
- Add a "What to Expect" section (3 clear steps)
- Pre-populate WhatsApp message link
- Fix blue default link colors to match palette

Phase 2: Content & Structure

- Rewrite homepage following recommended section order
- Break all paragraph blocks into max 2-3 sentences with spacing
- Add a FAQ section (4-5 common questions)
- Create "How It Works" visual 3-step flow
- Add explicit safety/confidentiality statement
- Address pricing (range or "investment starts at...")
- Add "Does this sound like you?" validation section
- Create dedicated pages for each specialization (SEO benefit)

Phase 3: Design & Polish

- Switch to warmer typography (serif headings + humanist sans body)
- Increase whitespace dramatically (80-120px between sections)
- Unify all colors — remove default blues
- Commission professional photography
- Add subtle scroll animations (fade-in sections)
- Remove Wix branding (upgrade plan)
- Implement consistent visual language across all pages
- Add custom favicon and Open Graph images

Phase 4: Platform & Premium (Custom Build)

- Migrate from Wix to a custom-built website (Laravel / modern stack)
- Implement proper SEO (schema markup for therapist, local business)
- Add a blog/resources section (authority building + SEO)
- Create an international clients page (timezone info, language support)
- Add Google Reviews widget or Trustpilot integration
- Consider a 30-60 second intro video for hero section
- Implement analytics and conversion tracking

- A/B test CTA copy and placement

Final Assessment

The site has a solid therapeutic philosophy and genuine personal story, but it's undermined by:

- Conversion architecture that requires too much initiative from anxious visitors
- Visual execution that reads as DIY rather than premium
- Content density that overwhelms rather than guides
- Trust gaps (single testimonial, Gmail, AI imagery) that don't match private-pay positioning

The core fix is structural: reduce words, increase whitespace, add a clear booking path visible at all times, and invest in the visual details that signal "this person takes their practice seriously enough to invest in it" — which is exactly what private-pay clients need to see before investing in you.

Ready to Transform Your Website?

I specialize in building custom, high-performance websites for professionals who need premium positioning and conversion-optimized experiences. Let's discuss how to bring this audit to life.

Rakesh Maity

Senior Software Engineer | Custom Laravel Development | Scalable Web Systems

Email	rakesh.maity@zohomail.in
WhatsApp	+91 9073090507
Upwork	upwork.com/freelancers/rakeshmaity
GitHub	github.com/rakeshmaity271

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